to India from the Middle East. In what I realize now to be a naïve attempt to dissuade her from this, I threatened her with exposure if she did not dissociate herself from the group.

On 11 March 1988 some people came to my flat accompanied by this girl Rita. I thought that she had brought members of the gang she worked with, so I told them that I had already intimated the Intelligence Service about them. This I did so that they would shy away from killing me or beating me up. I was dragged and pushed into a car waiting outside and it was only when I found myself in a police station that I realized my abductors were policemen. There I was questioned about whom I had informed in the Intelligence Service. I couldn't lie my way through. The station house inspector, Hukam Singh (name changed), then went out with Rita and came back after an hour with a group of people, of whom a couple looked like Afghanis; there were also a couple of Indian men and an Indian woman. They talked out of my hearing range for almost an hour and a half after which they went away leaving a briefcase behind. Rita handed over the keys of the briefcase to Hukam Singh, who, on opening it, declared that I had been carrying heroin with me. And ten kilograms at that. Later in the night I was beaten up badly and when I couldn't take [it] any more they made me sign some papers, some in Hindi and some in English.

The next day I was taken to the courts and there they produced before the magistrate what they claimed to be my confessional statement. It was stated in the court that Hukam Singh had received information that I would be carrying heroin with me and that my contact code would be 'Black Rose'. That was how I was apprehended in the vicinity of the police station.

I was supposed to be carrying heroin worth ten crores of rupees on my person and the police department was not even concerned about who my contact person was supposed to be? After being sent to prison the police had no more questions to ask me about where I had got ten crores worth of heroin from and whom I was going to supply it to? Did they think that was all the heroin there was in the market and that they had bust the whole racket by apprehending me? What hurts the most is not that the inspector, who is also the investigating officer, is obviously in the payroll of the Middle East-based gang but that even after six-and-a-half years of the progress of my trial no magistrate has even bothered to question him as to why I was not interrogated so that others of my so-called gang could be identified and apprehended.

A subinspector of police was jailed with us for some time. He told me that nothing could be done about my case because Inspector Hukam Singh was very influential in both the police as well as the judiciary circles. He is supposed to be holding an American green card and owns properties worth at least a couple of million dollars there. It all sounds plausible. I have written to various authorities about my case as well as what this subinspector told me. But to date no one has even responded to my complaints.

In December 1993 the president of India approved the setting up of ten special courts to expedite the NDPS Act cases and clear them by 12 December 1994. In 1995, only arguments, debates and disagreements on expeditious trials were going on. Events still move at a snail's pace. There has been no dramatic shift.

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'Medical care was bad,' recalled an Anglo-Indian woman prisoner who remained an undertrial even after four-and-a-half years. 'There would be prisoners suffering and who would be waiting for hours before the doctor came.' She went on to add: